airtime would be cut in half, with the second hour given to Erel Segal, a right-wing commentator who once contemplated running for parliament with the ruling party. “It’s no secret that I support Netanyahu and the Likud,” he said in 2015. “What was, a few years ago, the opinion of the hard right in Israel has now become the mainstream,” said Persico, the media reporter. “And I think journalists are looking around and seeing how the public opinion is moving.”

Israel prides itself on having the freest press in the Middle East, and often compares itself to the West in this regard. “As I can personally attest to you, the press in Israel is robust, free, very energetic, and free to say anything that it wants,” Netanyahu said in early 2016, during a press conference in Berlin with Angela Merkel, the German chancellor.

The newspaper was the dominant form of media in both the Yishuv, the pre-state Jewish community, and the first few decades after 1948. *Yediot Aharonot*, founded in 1939, is still the country’s largest paid newspaper, while the century-old *Ha’aretz* endures as the daily of choice for liberals in Tel Aviv. But there was also a rich tradition of partisan press. Mapai and Herut, the forerunners of today’s Labor and Likud, both had their own newspapers. So did the Revisionists, the Religious Zionists, the kibbutz movement, and even the Histadrut, the confederation of Israeli labor unions. As Israel’s national library put it, “In general, the Yishuv excelled in political polarization, and the reigning assumption was that each party needed a daily publication of its own.”[17]

The Israel Broadcasting Authority started radio transmissions in 1948, but it was the written word that really shaped public opinion. Television came late. The first proper broadcast channel didn’t launch until 1968, and it would not have any competition for another two decades. (The “Big Three” networks in the US, for comparison, all started broadcasting in the 1940s; the BBC started daily television newscasts in 1954.) Even today, Hebrew options are limited, particularly for news: the two private stations, plus the state-owned Channel 1. (In late 2016, Channel 20 was granted a news license.)

Non-Israelis often view *Ha’aretz* as the country’s newspaper of record, a sort of Israeli *New York Times* (the Grey Bubbe, if you will). But the paper actually has less than a 5 per cent market share. Outside of Tel Aviv, Haifa and other liberal redoubts, it is seen as angry and out-of-touch. Occasional headlines like “Israel is an evil state” do not endear it to the public. Most